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Food Production and Income Generation in a Matrilineal Society: Rural Women in Zomba, Malawi

DAVID HIRSCHMANN and MEGAN VAUGHAN

This article sets out to describe the various food-producing and income generating patterns found in rural households in the Zomba district of Malawi. The study focuses on women but it necessarily links women closely to their own households and the wider family groupings, characterised by matrilineal inheritance and matrilocal marriage, of which they are part.¹ Over 90 per cent of Malawians live in the rural areas and the country's people are overwhelmingly dependent on small-holder agriculture for food. Wage employment and exports are also provided very largely by the agricultural sector. People in Zomba, one of the twenty four districts in the country, have perhaps greater access to urban wages and markets as the former colonial and post-colonial capital is situated at the centre of the district and remains a relatively busy market, commercial, administrative and educational centre. But much of the district is rural and it includes a wide range of agricultural environments and cropping patterns. Zomba is not one of the Malawian districts in which small-holders produce a very considerable surplus for export, but local farmers, working intensively on small plots of land, still mainly with hoes, manage to produce and sometimes sell a wide range of crops.

As a recent study by Kydd and Christiansen has shown, the economy of Malawi has undergone important structural changes since independence.² Not least as a result of government policy in the spheres of pricing, loans, land expropriation and protection, marketed output from the estate sector has overtaken that from the

¹ Information in this article is based on a survey carried out between April and June 1981, in the rural area of Zomba district, in Southern Malawi. We interviewed 70 women, who came from 54 villages within a 20 mile radius of the Zomba Municipal boundary. These villages can be clustered into 19 geographical groupings and they fell into 8 Traditional Authority areas. Interviews were conducted using a questionnaire which focused mainly on agricultural production. However, the interviews were also 'open-ended', in the sense that questions which seemed of particular importance to individual women were explored in some depth. With the help of a female interpreter/adviser, all interviews were undertaken personally by the authors. For a fuller account of the results of this survey see D. Hirschmann and M. Vaughan, *Women Farmers and Food production in the Zomba District of Malawi*, Berkeley, Institute of International Studies, University of California, forthcoming.

² J. Kydd and R. Christiansen, 'Structural Change in Malawi since Independence: Consequences of a Development Strategy Based on Large-Scale Agriculture', *World Development*, Vol.10, No.5, May 1982, pp.355–77.

smallholder sector. There has been a rapid development of estate tea and sugar production in the South and especially of estate tobacco production in the Central Region. Further, while Malawi served as a major supplier of migrant workers until the early 1970s, when possibly 500,000 Malawians worked outside the country largely in Zimbabwe, South Africa and Zambia, opportunities for such long distance migrancy have subsequently been seriously curtailed. Kydd and Christiansen argue that much of the male labour force previously employed outside the country has been absorbed not into smallholder production, but into the burgeoning estate sector as low-paid agricultural wage labourers. In the inter-censal period (1966–1977) the proportion of economically active males engaged in full or part-year wage employment doubled to reach a half. By 1977, 69.3 per cent of the total number of individuals working on their own holdings were women. Such figures indicate a substantial shift of male labour away from smallholder production.

Recent changes in Zomba district seem to reflect the national trends. The 1977 census shows that the growth-rate for females in Zomba district is considerably higher than that for males, and that the disproportion is most marked in the areas of highest population density.³ This and other evidence points to the conclusion that there is increasing male migration from the most crowded parts of the district. The pattern of male migration has also changed since 1966, and now involves more younger men. Many of these men are absent at work in the Central Region of the country, either in the new capital city of Lilongwe, or on the tobacco estates of Kasungu district.⁴ The effect of increased internal migration of young men on households must be seen in conjunction with the phenomenon of an exceptionally high divorce rate. According to the 1977 Census, the percentage of divorced or separated women in Zomba district is substantially higher than the national average. In the 20–24 age-range, 13.7 per cent of women are divorced or separated (compared to the national average of 7.5 per cent). As women become older, the

³ In Zomba District as a whole the annual growth rate for females in the inter-censal period was 2.4%, while for males it was 1.8%. In the areas of highest population density – that is, Traditional Authority areas Mwambo and Chikowi, the ratio of females to males has grown most markedly in the inter-censal period:

	Sex Ratio	Females/Males
	1966	1977
Zomba District	1.02	1.08
T.A. Areas:		
Kuntumanje	1.07	1.07
Mwambo	0.96	1.08
Malemia	1.02	1.11
Chikowi	1.09	1.14
Mlumbé	1.10	1.13

Source: Calculated from *Malawi Population Census, 1977*, Vol.I.

⁴ In 1977 there was a total of 10,932 males who were born in Zomba district but who were enumerated in the Central Region. The corresponding total for females was 7,044. There were also large numbers of males born in Zomba district who were currently resident in other districts of the Southern Region, but in these cases the balance of the sexes was much more even, indicating perhaps that families were moving together. For instance, in 1977 there were 10,884 males and 12,426 females who had been born in Zomba district but who were enumerated in neighbouring Machinga district. Other information indicates that a large proportion of these figures can be accounted for by the movement of whole families from Zomba to Machinga in search of land. Calculated from *Malawi Population Census, 1977*.

proportion of divorcees increases, so that 17.4 per cent of women in the age-range 45–49 were divorced or separated (compared to the national average of 10.4 per cent). We do not know for how long, on average, a woman remains unmarried when she has been divorced or separated, but it is clear that a significant proportion of women will spend at least some of their adult lives without a husband.

The combined effects of increasing male migration and high divorce rates has resulted in a high proportion of female-headed households. Calculations from the 1977 Census show that out of a total of 106,625 households in the Zomba district, 36,529 or 34 per cent are female-headed (i.e. the woman considers herself to be the head of the household), and in a further 12.6 per cent of cases where a woman is working full-time on the land, the husband is in full-time employment off the family farm. The National Sample Survey of Agriculture for 1980–81 shows that of the 480 households sampled in Zomba district, 36.9 per cent were headed by women.⁵ In our own small sample of 70 women, 31.4 per cent were living without husbands; and in a further 12 per cent of cases the husband was more or less permanently away from the home.

None of these features is new in Zomba. A survey in the Domasi area in 1949 showed that around 30 per cent of able-bodied men were ‘usually’ absent from home, either as labour migrants or in employment or trade within the country.⁶ A high divorce rate in this area was noted by Clyde Mitchell, the anthropologist, around the same time and such instability of marriage may well be a deeply rooted structural feature of the local matrilineal-matrilocal societies.⁷ Over a long period, social arrangements in which women have strong rights over land allocation and use, and in which the female sorority group (*mbumba*) is perhaps the most stable unit have been cemented.⁸ But while such forms of social organization are not new, the absence of men, the divorce rate and the number of female heads of households may be increasing. And additional pressures are put on the economic viability of a largely female agriculture by the increasingly severe crisis in land availability. The problems of population pressure and land shortage are clearly visible. Population density in the rural areas of the district increased from 81 per sq. kilometre in 1966 to 121 per sq. kilometre in 1977. This is the fifth highest district figure for population density in the country, and is double the national average. Population density and holding sizes vary very widely within the district, but the National Sample Survey of Agriculture for 1980/81 found that the mean area cultivated per household in

⁵ Malawi Government, *National Sample Survey of Agriculture for Customary Land 1980/81: Preliminary Report*. National Statistical Office, Zomba, 1982. Table 1.

⁶ These figures are derived from an economic survey of the Domasi area of Zomba District, carried out in 1949: National Archives of Malawi: NS/3/3/2 Domasi Paper No.2: An Area Assessment.

⁷ J. C. Mitchell, ‘An Estimate of Fertility in some Yao hamlets in the Liwonde District of Southern Nyasaland’ *Africa* Vol. XIX, No. 4, 1949, p. 298. Mitchell estimated that between $\frac{1}{3}$ and $\frac{1}{2}$ of marriages contracted by women had ended in divorce by the time the child-bearing period had ended.

⁸ The *mbumba* consists of a group of sisters resident in their maternal village, whose welfare is, at least theoretically, protected by an elder brother, or sometimes an uncle (*asyene mbumba*). If the women are married, then the *asyene mbumba* will also take responsibility in some measure for the welfare of his nieces and nephews. The ideology of matriliney in this area seems to focus around the *mbumba* unit, and this has also been adopted by President Kamuzu Banda who refers to all women in Malawi as ‘my *mbumba*’.

Zomba district was 0.7 hectares.⁹ For a large number of households in the district shortage of land is already a critical problem, and with an annual population growth rate of around 2.4 per cent this can only get worse.

The results of our own survey must be seen in the context of this combination of circumstances. Our questions were explicitly directed towards the preliminary task of discovering more about the role of women in agricultural production at the present time, and centred on basic issues such as the type of crops grown, methods used and problems encountered. The limited nature of the sample and our decision to omit any deep longitudinal investigation, which would have entailed recreating the histories of individual households over a long period of time, make it difficult to come to firm conclusions about the directions of social change. However, the answers have revealed interesting material on women's control over property, and the allocation of labour and decision making within the household, which are suggestive of both the solidity of, and strains within, matrilineal forms. They also show both points of similarity and contrasts with patterns of change in areas of southern/central Africa where women have less fixed rights in property.

Land, Labour and Food Production

When Clyde Mitchell studied land tenure in an area just north of Zomba district in the 1940s, he found that women had a high degree of security of tenure, whilst men had very little.¹⁰ Individual women, under this matrilineal inheritance system, tended to retain the same garden through successive marriages and through periods without a spouse. This system seems to have survived intact to the present day. Most of the married women, and almost all the widowed and divorced women interviewed, were resident either in the village of their birth, or in a village in which a number of their maternal relatives were also living. Most women stated that they had obtained their plots of land from the Village Headman, or directly from a mother or grandmother, and 80 per cent of women said that they would not lose their land in the event of a divorce or separation. Although the Village Headman has the formal right of land allocation and reallocation, it appears that his control has become less crucial as the amount of uncultivated land in the area has decreased. In practice, even if land is formally inherited by women *through* the Village Headman, the plots which women acquire are usually those which have been worked by their mothers, grandmothers and other maternal relatives.

Although we encountered some instances of Village Headmen reallocating land between and within families, individual *mbumba* groups generally have rights to a fairly well-defined area of land, which is passed on from one generation to another. It is possibly as a result of this system, and the non-availability of vacant land in most areas, that land-holdings are so unequally distributed within villages. In our sample of seventy, twelve women either had no land, or had only a token plot around their houses, while five had more than sufficient for their needs. Within one village the

⁹ Malawi Government, *National Sample Survey of Agriculture*, 1980/81 Table 1.

¹⁰ J. C. Mitchell, 'Land Tenure and Agriculture among the Machinga Yao', *Nyasaland Journal*, Vol.2, 1952, pp.18–31.

variations in holding size could be enormous. In all, 57 per cent of the women interviewed said that they had insufficient land for their needs, and as a result of this, even if they had enough labour and cash for fertiliser, they felt they would still be unable to grow sufficient staple food to feed their families. Thus although the vast majority of women had well established *rights* to land in their maternal villages, there were many instances where the amount of land available to them was not sufficient to provide them with the basis for economic independence.

The agricultural strategies adopted by different women reflected, more than anything else, the amount of land available to them. It was the main aim of the vast majority of women to grow enough staple food to last the whole year, but 69 per cent of women said that they were unable to achieve this. In terms of food sufficiency there was a clear difference between women who had husbands living with them and those who did not. Of our total sample, 38 had husbands living with them, and 20 of these produced sufficient food. Of the 32 women who had no husband, or whose husbands were absent, only 8 produced enough staple food. In some cases this difference may have been a reflection of the value of the man's labour contribution, but more crucially it was connected to the availability of land – men tended to remain at home when there was enough land to render their labour productive. The difference could not be accounted for by men bringing land to a marriage. There were only twelve cases of men who cultivated land in their own villages, and in some of these cases the produce of that land was going to another wife and her family. About half the women had their food supply supplemented by the gifts of relatives and friends. A female support system emerged clearly since most assistance was coming from sisters and mothers. Very little food was received from male relatives.

The main crop grown in Zomba district is maize, though in the less well-watered areas cassava is also an important staple, and in areas bordering on Lake Chilwa rice is grown in significant quantities. The 1980/81 National Sample Survey of Agriculture found that 89.5 per cent of the cultivated area in their Zomba sample was planted with maize or maize mixtures.¹¹ Our own sample illustrated this heavy emphasis on maize, but it also indicated that women with sufficient land generally grew a wide variety of crops, albeit in small quantities. Some women had upwards of twenty different crops growing in their gardens, including many different kinds of pulses and green leaves, as well as supplementary staples such as cassava, sorghum and millet. Women with less land tended to concentrate more heavily on maize production and grew fewer of the supplementary crops. In 98 per cent of cases the maize grown was of the local variety, the women selecting seed from their stores each year to plant the following season. Hybrid maize was grown by only two households, and composite maize (U.C.A.) by six.¹² (These figures accord with the

¹¹ Malawi Government, *National Sample Survey of Agriculture*, 1980/81 Table 5.

¹² Hybrid maize is an 'improved' variety, the seeds of which can be bought at ADMARC (Agricultural Development and Marketing Corporation) selling points. New seeds have to be bought each year in the case of hybrid, while the seeds of composite maize can be selected from the previous year's crop and replanted. The recommended composite for planting in this area is Ukiriguru Composite A (UCA). Both hybrids and composites require careful fertiliser application, and in the case of hybrids, insecticide is needed in order to protect the harvested crop from pest infestation. In this area a farmer wishing to experiment with hybrid maize needs to take out a credit 'package' of seed and fertiliser, and his garden has to be measured by an Agricultural Extension Officer to ensure that it is large enough. The seed of composite varieties is more readily available as it can be re-used.

findings of the 1980/81 National Sample Survey of Agriculture which shows that only 0.4 per cent of the cultivated area in Zomba district was planted to hybrid maize, and 0.5 per cent to composite maize.) Next to local maize the most frequently grown crop was cassava. In most cases this was grown primarily as a supplement to maize, but it was also an important cash-crop for many women. Of those who grew cassava, 41 per cent sold some of it, and many also used dried cassava for brewing beer.

The overwhelming majority (97 per cent) of women interviewed grew most or all of their maize mixed with other crops. Virtually all agricultural operations are still performed with a hoe. The ground is hoed into ridges before the onset of the rains, and at the beginning of the rains the maize is planted in these ridges. Sometimes the maize seeds are mixed in advance with other seeds, such as pumpkin, and a mixed handful is planted in each planting station. In other cases the maize is systematically interplanted on a ridge with one or more crops, such as groundnuts, pigeon peas or beans. This practice, and the preference for local maize, is significant given the current extension advice in the area which places heavy emphasis on planting 'improved varieties' of maize 'pure-stand'.

Zomba district is not yet a 'development area' under the Malawi National Rural Development Programme and therefore has not received the increased input of credit facilities, extension advice and infrastructure which has been provided in areas such as that covered by the Lilongwe Land Development Programme.¹³ In Zomba the ratio of extension worker to farmer is in the order of 1 : 2,000,¹⁴ and extension workers tend to concentrate their attentions on the more affluent farmers who are most able to respond to their advice. As might be expected, very few of the women we interviewed had ever had any direct contact with the extension service, but nevertheless most of them had a fairly clear idea (through listening to radio programmes and attending Malawi Congress Party meetings) of the kind of advice offered. It was clear from their comments that the current extension advice proffered in the area was wholly inappropriate and irrelevant to them, and that even if they had had more direct contact with the extension service they would have been unlikely to have changed their agricultural practices.¹⁵ The vexed question of bias against women by the extension service was in fact only really of any relevance when considering the richer households. For the majority it was a case of in-built bias against poorer farmers as it affected women in particular.

Over the last twenty years, the most important technical advance in smallholder agriculture has been the widespread availability of fertiliser. The fact that 60 per cent of women surveyed used fertiliser is not, however, indicative of the advance of 'progressive agricultural methods', but rather of a response to decreasing plot sizes and depleted soils — as the women fully recognised. Many use fertiliser no longer

¹³ Zomba district will be divided into three areas under the Malawi National Rural Development Programme — Zomba West, Zomba East and Zaone (which covers the south). These areas are scheduled to become part of NRDP sometime in the 1980s, though current funding problems are delaying the time schedule for the whole country.

¹⁴ Ministry of Agriculture and Natural Resources, *Survey Report No.40, Zomba West*, Lilongwe, 1980, p.15.

recommended by the extension service. But the acquisition of fertiliser has become crucial to maize production, and one of the main problems they face every year is how to raise enough cash to purchase this increasingly expensive, but essential input.

Most women had not changed their agricultural practices over the previous few years, but innovation and experimentation were evident nonetheless, and seemed more common amongst either the better-off or the very poor. The better-off women, with more land, were occasionally experimenting with composite maize and following advice they had received directly or indirectly from the extension service. The poorer women were often experimenting more out of desperation. One woman had begun to grow sorghum to replace the maize which was doing badly in her garden; another was experimenting with bulrush millet for the same reason, though she had never grown it before. Both of these crops are cereals which used to be grown in large quantities in this area but which, for at least sixty years, have been superseded by maize. Neither of these women had eaten sorghum or millet as their main staple before. More than 70 per cent of women had stopped growing one crop or another over recent years because of specific problems in cultivation – the most commonly cited crop in this category was beans.

Although access to land was perhaps the most important factor in determining agricultural strategy, the availability of labour could also be significant, particularly in the cases of women without husbands and with heavy child-care responsibilities. In order to maintain food production in the face of land shortage, smallholder farmers have had to rely on an intensification of labour combined, sometimes, with the application of fertiliser. Some households in our survey had reached the critical point where land-holdings were so small that the intensification of labour even when fertiliser was used, was no longer repaid in higher yields. It was from such households that husbands tended to leave to find wage labour. There were other cases, however, where the labour of a husband or of a hired labourer was crucial to the maintenance of food production.

The extent to which agricultural production depended on the labour of women emerged dramatically from our survey. Women's predominance in farm work was clear in all households whether or not a husband was present. In cases where

¹⁵ Many women gave clear reasons why they would be unable to grow improved varieties of seed and follow extension advice. The main reason in the case of hybrid maize was that they did not have enough land to enable them to grow it 'pure stand', as required. This was coupled with the fact that they did not feel financially secure enough to take out a large credit package. Hybrid maize also has certain specific disadvantages for women whose prime concern is growing food for immediate consumption. Some of these factors enumerated by the women were: it is difficult to store; it does not pound well; the taste is not liked; it cannot be eaten 'green'. Given that most women were growing local varieties of maize, there were good agricultural reasons for planting this crop mixed with other crops. The following figures for yields of 'pure stand' and 'mixed' local maize for Zomba district, illustrate this clearly.

Mean Yields (kg per hectare)

local maize (pure stand)	857
local maize mixed with pulses	1119
local maize mixed with cassava	898
composite maize	726

Source: *National Sample Survey of Agriculture 1980/81*

husbands were living more or less permanently on the family farm with their wives (that is in only about 55 per cent of cases), men and women shared most tasks in the production of maize, but women often took sole responsibility for harvesting, storage and seed selection. It was noticeable that while in many cases women in married households took *sole* responsibility for certain agricultural tasks, men were always supported in their labour by wives and/or labourers and children. Men contributed most to the tasks of land preparation, weeding, fertiliser application and planting. The labour of children was much more important in households where the husband was absent, and in these households women also relied more on the help of female relatives, especially in harvesting. Most significantly, the proportion of households hiring labour was higher in those families where a husband was present than in those where he was not. This indicated that households where husbands are present tend to be those with enough land to absorb extra labour, and enough cash to pay this labour.

Some 44 per cent of households in our sample employed labour in one form or another, though the nature of this employment varied enormously. A few households employed permanent labourers who lived close to their employers and worked and ate with them; the majority employed only very casual labour for the completion of certain tasks, such as weeding. In our sample there were eight women who themselves sometimes performed casual agricultural labour (*ganyu*) in order to raise cash. Some women doing *ganyu* were caught in a 'vicious circle'. Typically they ran out of maize after six months or so and needed cash urgently in order to buy food. The easiest way to raise cash was to do casual labour for more fortunate households at peak labour periods, but this necessarily involved withdrawing labour from their own plots. In general, though, women made a very shrewd reckoning of the relative values of their labour on their own land and its 'market' value. One woman both hired-in labour for land preparation, and hired-out her own labour during weeding time, and explained in detail how this was rational in terms of her own household's resources.

The households where labour shortage could be crucial were composed of women without resident husbands and with a number of young children. These women necessarily spent much of their time in household and child-care duties, had many mouths to feed, and their children were too young to contribute much valuable labour. Some women in this situation were able to hire labour, usually with cash sent by absent husbands, but others did not have this cash available and consequently had to practice a less labour-intensive agriculture.

Clyde Mitchell noted in the 1940s that the principle of 'labour determines ownership' applied to agricultural produce in this region.¹⁶ The same appears to be true today, with the predominance of female labour giving women a great deal of control over the disposal of the crop. We need to be careful, however, in equating this with female economic power, because in households where a husband was present and where a quantity of produce was grown for sale, men exerted a significant degree of control over sales. Where husbands were present the majority of

¹⁶ Mitchell, 'Land Tenure and Agriculture', p.24.

agricultural decisions were made jointly, though decisions involving the expenditure of large amounts of cash were most often made by the husband. For instance, in 82 per cent of cases where a husband was present, it was he who made the decision to buy fertiliser, and in 75 per cent of cases it was he who employed and paid labour. In such households, the decision to sell agricultural produce was also usually made jointly, except in the case of *dimba* produce. *Dimba* gardens are pieces of land which due to proximity to some source of water (a stream or a spring), retain their moisture for all or most of the year. They are a very valuable asset as they allow households to grow vegetables out of season, which can either be consumed or sold. Even in households where husbands are present, women seem to retain firm control over the sale of *dimba* produce, and this seems to be directly connected to their labour contribution on these plots. *Dimba* gardens are 'women's' gardens, and the proceeds of sales of *dimba* produce usually accrue to them.

Men, Women and Household Income

The fact that 69 per cent of women interviewed were unable to grow their basic food requirements is a clear indication of the importance of off-farm incomes in this area. Of course, even when women were more or less self-sufficient in staple food, they all needed to buy 'relish';¹⁷ most had to buy fertiliser; all had to buy salt, soap, clothing and Malawi Congress Party membership cards;¹⁸ some were paying school fees for their children, and some were hiring labour. Thus, whilst the main focus of women's activities is the production of staple food crops, they are all dependent to some degree on cash incomes and, it would seem, increasingly dependent on some form of non-agricultural income. It is in considering household income as a whole, rather than just agricultural income, that the significance of marriage and male employment emerges most clearly.

Although female employment is growing relatively fast in Malawi, this is from a very small base.¹⁹ There were no employed women in our sample but there were a number of women whose husbands had some sort of regular employment. Except for those who were too sick or too old, all the men who were living with their wives, plus some who were absent but in contact with their families, were earning cash, and about 60 per cent of these had what the women considered to be 'regular' employment. These included migrant workers in South Africa, forestry workers, domestic servants and permanent labourers in government departments. The less permanently employed men included traders, temporary agricultural labourers, and artisans

¹⁷ 'Relish' is the term used for a dish of meat, fish or vegetables which is eaten along with the staple maize porridge (*nsima*). A meal is thought to be complete only when both *nsima* and relish are eaten.

¹⁸ Membership of the Malawi Congress Party is compulsory for all adults and a membership card costs 50 tambala per annum. It is difficult to avoid paying this due because it is collected by party officials at the village level, and membership checks at the gates to markets, and on buses, are regularly carried out. If a woman arrives either to buy or sell produce at a market and is found not to have a current membership card, she is turned away.

¹⁹ The percentage annual growth rate for wage and salaried employment for females in the intercensal period (1966–77) was 17.8, compared to the male growth rate of 9.8. Kydd and Christiansen, 'Structural Change', Table 7, p.363.

working on their own. Without a detailed household survey over a year it is difficult to assess the actual importance of the cash contributions of husbands, but it is significant that the most prosperous households we encountered were those where not only was there enough land available, but also there was capital from a husband's present or past earnings to invest in production or trade.

Virtually all women interviewed (91 per cent) earned some cash themselves. This was vital for the women without any male support, but it was also important for most of the married women. The majority of women, 80 per cent of the total, earned cash primarily from the sale of their own agricultural produce. Even if their households were in overall food deficit, as so many were, selling produce was the easiest, quickest and sometimes the only way for women to raise occasional small amounts of cash. In fact the poorer their household the more likely women were to have to sell their 'luxury' crops such as fruits. The most commonly sold crop was bananas, followed by cassava, sugar-cane, groundnuts, sweet potatoes, pigeon peas, cow peas, pawpaws, guavas and avocado pears. By the very nature of the crops, most of these sales were seasonal and sporadic, although the pulses, groundnuts and cassava could be dried and sold all year round. As already noted, women with access to *dimba* land were at a considerable advantage in being able to grow many crops out of season, and sales of *dimba* produce were thus an important source of income to many women.

The vast majority of women sold only very small amounts of produce at a time – a bunch of bananas, a dozen tomatoes, a few sticks of sugar cane. They might be earning as little as 20–30 tambala a week in this way. Those who sold more than this were mostly women who had access to a larger than average plot of land, and whose husbands were either active farmers or earned and remitted a significant amount of money. One example will perhaps illustrate how land sufficiency, male participation and agricultural sales could be associated.

Mrs M. was married to a village headman and had one small child. Because of the husband's status the marriage was virilocal – the couple lived in the husband's village and had access to a large plot of land about half a mile away from the house. It was clear that this couple's access to land was linked to the husband's local political status, for in the same village we interviewed a woman who had only a 'token' plot around her house. Husband and wife worked full-time on the land, and they grew a wide variety of crops. The plot of land was large enough for them to be able to rotate crops in it, and to dispense with fertiliser. On this piece of land they grew maize, sorghum, sweet potatoes, cassava, yams, groundnuts, and a variety of pulses. Mrs M. came from a village about one mile away and still had access to land in that village, including a *dimba* plot. She and her husband went there together to cultivate her land and they grew a variety of crops there which complemented the mixture grown at her husband's village, including rice, millet and cow peas. This household's income was apparently totally derived from the sale of agricultural produce. The main source of cash was maize sales, but they also sold vegetables, and Mrs M. sometimes sold maize flour and scones.

This was an exceptional household because of the amount of land jointly available to the couple. Perhaps more typical of the 'successful' households was that of Mrs

T. She was aged 42 and married to a retired policeman who was currently working for a firm in Blantyre (about 50 miles away) and returned home every other weekend. Both husband and wife had more education than average, and they had nine children aged between one and twenty-three. Mrs T. was living in her maternal village. She had inherited from her mother two large gardens, plus a *dimba* garden. She grew a wide variety of crops and had for the past three years been visited by an extension officer. She employed one labourer all year round, and he was paid with money given to her by her husband. Her husband's current wage and pension also paid for school fees, clothing and fertiliser. Mrs T. was able to grow enough maize to feed her family all year, but for buying 'relish' and other small items, she raised cash through the sale of cassava and sugar cane (which she grew on her *dimba* land).

In most households, both poor and relatively wealthy, the sale of agricultural produce was only one part of an overall income-earning strategy. A wide variety of strategies emerged from our survey. One woman sold beer and a distilled alcoholic drink, *kachasu*,²⁰ once a month. She also sold some maize once a week in the months October to February (when the price was highest). Another did *ganyu* labour about twice a month, and sold vegetables once or twice a week. Her husband did *ganyu* labour once a week, but some of his earnings went to support another wife. Another woman received a small amount of money (about 15 kwacha) twice a year from her migrant husband. She also occasionally sold maize and beans, but most of her income came from trading in maize which she bought, processed into flour, and resold, about twice a week.

In most households, then, total income was derived from a number of different sources. In married households there was frequently a considerable dependence on male earnings derived from employment or trade, often combined with female earnings from the sale of agricultural produce. In the poorer married households one or both partners sometimes performed *ganyu* labour. Women without husbands were obviously much more dependent on their own earnings, though some of them received cash from other relatives. In fact 47 per cent of the sample (and mainly those without husbands present) received some cash assistance from outside the immediate household. Here the pattern of assistance differed from that noted for food assistance. In the latter case assistance came predominantly from female relatives, while cash assistance came mainly from brothers, sons and married daughters. Amongst older women cash remittances from adult sons and daughters were very important, often enabling them to hire labour or buy fertiliser. Younger women often had small children and this affected their ability to trade and do wage labour. A common cash-earning strategy amongst such women was to brew and sell both beer and *kachasu*.

Marriage and Matrilineage

As indicated earlier, about one third of the women interviewed were unmarried, divorced, permanently separated or widowed, and 14 per cent had husbands who

²⁰ It is illegal to distil *kachasu* within town and municipal boundaries, and therefore women who live close to the municipal boundary have a ready market for their product.

lived most of the time elsewhere. Although women heading households do have some specific problems, it would be wrong to assume that they have always necessarily been poorer than married women. However, there is some indication that, as land becomes scarcer and as agricultural production per capita stagnates or declines, so dependence on off-farm income will increase still further. Women are restricted by their household and child-care duties, by their lack of education and training, as well as by the preconceptions and prejudices of employers, in their ability to earn cash away from their homes. To this extent, women in the area may be becoming more dependent on a marriage tie. At the same time, however, the opportunities for relatively well-paid migrant labour for men are becoming scarce, forcing more and more men to accept low-paid agricultural labour within the country. Women with husbands away performing this kind of wage labour are not necessarily much better off than those without husbands at all. Economic differentiation in the area would thus appear to hinge on two main factors: the extent of a household's access to land, and, secondly, the opportunities for relatively well-paid wage labour or profitable trade. Most of the wealthier households we encountered combined the advantages of both, generally over a considerable period of time. Undoubtedly the poorest households were those where there was little land available and no regular or significant off-farm income, and where land was particularly scarce men tended to be absent.

The effects on women of this cycle of deprivation are partially moderated by the functioning of the family networks in which they live. Almost all women lived close to at least some of their maternal relatives – commonly their mothers, sisters and aunts. Although each woman usually ran a separate household, there was a great deal of informal mutual aid and food-sharing between women. This was particularly evident in the case of young divorced women who were living in close proximity to their mothers. Whilst there was little formal sharing of agricultural labour – harvesting being the only operation in which women said they regularly co-operated – there was a great deal of co-operation in the labour intensive task of food processing, and in other household duties and child care. Furthermore, single women and their children often ate communally with maternal relatives, and it was clear that households with severe food deficits were helped in this way. One example, amongst many, illustrates this.

Mrs N. was twenty-six years old and recently divorced. She had two children and lived in her maternal village very close to her parents, maternal grandmother, brothers, sisters and nieces. She had access to land in the village on which she grew maize and cassava, but nothing else. When her husband had been living with her they had grown more crops and had also hired labour, but since he had left her (he did not send any money), she had not had the cash to do this. She was able to grow enough staple food to feed herself and her children for about eight months of the year, but she did not grow any crops which could be used for 'relish'. For this she relied entirely on her mother and sisters, and she always ate with them. Most of her agricultural and household decisions were made jointly with her mother, and if one of her children was sick, it was to her mother and sisters that she turned for help.

It was clear that, since her divorce, Mrs N. had relied a great deal on the support

provided by a maternal family network. In contrast, Mrs T., another divorced woman, was without such support, and her plight was much more serious. Mrs T. was living in a very small, temporary-looking hut with no windows. She had four children and had been divorced for about one year. She came originally from a village close to Zomba town, but on marriage she had moved to her husband's village. This decision appears to have been made in response to the severe land shortage in her own village, and the fact that her husband had access to a relatively large plot of land in his own village. On divorce she had had to leave her husband's village and could not return to her own village because there was no land available there and most of her maternal relatives were either dead, or had moved elsewhere. She had gone from place to place trying to find somewhere to stay until she had found a headman who had given her a small plot of land on which to build a house. This is where she was living with three of her four children at the time of interview. Her garden consisted of the surrounds of her house where she had planted a few rows of maize, cassava, sorghum and vegetables. She had had no money with which to buy fertiliser and had planted the crops so closely together that none had grown well. When interviewed at the end of March the family had already harvested and consumed the whole of the coming year's maize supply. She said that her children had been very hungry and she had been unable to prevent them from eating the maize 'green' as there was no other food available. Her younger children showed clear signs of malnutrition.

Mrs T. received no money from her former husband, nor from any relatives, but she did receive food occasionally from her sister who was living about fifteen miles away. She had thought of going to stay there, but was reluctant to do so because her sister was living in her husband's village, and so she would be an outsider there and not eligible for any land. Her main cash-earning strategy was to brew and sell beer. In the month before the interview she had brewed beer and earned around thirty kwacha. She hoped to do this more frequently, but as most of her profit had gone towards buying essential foodstuffs and clothing, she did not have much left over with which to buy the ingredients for the next brew. She said that she was a complete stranger in the village in which she lived, and received no direct help from anyone there. It seemed fair to assume that, had Mrs T. lived in close proximity to a group of maternal relations then her plight might not have been so desperate, and she could have concentrated more on raising cash and less on the immediate food needs of her family. Mrs T. was in an exceptionally difficult situation but one, it could be argued, likely to become more common in areas of highest population density. Her case serves to show, in a negative way, the importance of the wide family network in supporting single women and those 'at risk'. For how long the maternal family would support someone like Mrs T., however, is not clear. Neither do we know the likelihood of re-marriage for women who are living as 'guests' in strange villages.

Conclusion

Clearly the women we interviewed are not a homogeneous group. Some of their households are engaged in a long-standing struggle to maintain a minimum standard

of living; others are responding to a sudden or creeping crisis in land, labour or cash availability, or some combination of these; some have long accepted off-farm income as central to their survival, while others have only recently been obliged to accept this; and a few are attempting to improve their material conditions primarily through increased agricultural production. The circumstances to which these households are responding are many and varied. They include increasing land pressure, off-farm employment opportunities, market facilities, prices of goods produced and consumed, and the vagaries of local politics in the allocation and re-allocation of resources (particularly land) and other favours.

On the surface there appears to be a large element of continuity in the pattern of the lives of these women. Many of the problems which pre-occupy them today, and many of the situations in which they find themselves are not unfamiliar ones. The phenomenon of female-headed households is not a new one in a society with an in-built tendency towards a high divorce rate, and a long history of male involvement in trade and labour migration. The apparent resilience of the matrilineal systems in the area may owe something to this long history of temporary male absence. Similarly the large responsibility for food production taken by women could be seen as different only in degree from a long-standing situation of female dominance in agriculture.

The differences noted, and the continuities observed, whilst both important, should not, however, obscure the fact that there are changes taking place in the area which may have profound effects on women's lives. These changes can be most clearly seen in the cases of the poorest households; but it seems probable that they will become more general as increasing land shortage takes its toll. It is true that the matrilineal family system gives women security in their access to land, and a significant degree of control over this resource. Yet, as land pressure grows, and more and more families come to depend on off-farm incomes for their livelihood, so women are likely to become more dependent on a 'male' income and a marriage tie. Women will find themselves relegated increasingly to the least productive sector of the local economy — their control over land and agricultural production no longer providing them with the power and independence it had in the past.